

Reigning With Life Within This Life

Antioch Frames the Difference Between Law and Sonship

Open to Galatians 2. We will begin again with the encounter at Antioch.

We have been defining the difference between the covenant God made with Abraham, the law that was added four hundred and thirty years later because of transgressions, and the sonship that the Abrahamic covenant resulted in.

By the law was the knowledge of sin. But the covenant with Abraham pointed to sonship.

At Antioch and Galatia, Judaism became rampant. Certain men came from James, the pastor in Jerusalem, to Antioch. Before they came, Peter ate with the Gentiles. After they came, he was caught up in dissimulation, along with Barnabas and others.

Judaism finally accepted that the Gentile could become Abraham's seed by accepting Jesus Christ. That was hard for Jews to accept. These Gentiles who had not kept the law were suddenly stepping into the inheritance promised to Abraham's seed.

So the Judaizers said, "Paul is preaching truth in part, but he does not understand that after Gentiles are born again and become Abraham's seed, they must go on to keep the law to be perfected."

That is why Paul says in Galatians 3:

"O foolish Galatians, who hath bewitched you?"

Who is practicing witchcraft on you, that you began in the spirit, in the new birth that freed you from sin, and now think you will be perfected by the law?

When Paul asks who ministers the Spirit among them, he is not primarily talking about the baptism of the Holy Ghost. He is asking, "Who ministers this born-again life to you? Were you saved by hearing the law or by hearing faith in Jesus Christ?"

Paul Withstood Peter Because Grace Was at Stake

Galatians 2:11 says:

"But when Peter was come to Antioch,
I withstood him to the face,
because he was to be blamed."

How would you like to withstand one of the original apostles to his face? You would need to know what you were doing.

I believe that is why Paul was born out of due season. He said he received this gospel not from man but from God. While even Peter was caught up in dissimulation, Paul came at a critical time, when Judaizers were about to take the foundation of grace away from the church. He stepped in and turned it back.

Galatians 2:12-13 says:

"For before that certain came from James,
he did eat with the Gentiles:
but when they were come,
he withdrew and separated himself,
fearing them which were of the circumcision.
And the other Jews dissembled likewise with him;
insomuch that Barnabas also was carried away with their dissimulation."

Dissimulation means hypocrisy.

I used to picture Peter at a big banquet, fellowshiping with Gentiles, and when the men from James walked in, the Jews suddenly moved away. But that was not the issue. Peter was eating food that was not kosher.

Peter had already seen the sheet in Joppa. God told him not to call common or unclean what He had cleansed. Peter had been eating as the Gentiles ate. When the Judaizers arrived, he withdrew and went back toward the law.

Requiring Gentiles to Keep the Law Made Christ a Minister of Sin

Paul says:

"But when I saw that they walked not uprightly according to the truth of the gospel,
I said unto Peter before them all,
If thou, being a Jew, livest after the manner of Gentiles,
and not as do the Jews,
why compellest thou the Gentiles to live as do the Jews?"

Peter, you were a Jew. If the law saved you, why did you leave it? You were born again by the blood of Jesus and began living like a Gentile, apart from the law. Now you are compelling Gentiles to live like Jews.

If you say Gentiles must keep the law after receiving Christ, you are saying the blood of Jesus was not enough to save them. Then you make Christ a minister of sin.

Paul continues:

"For if I build again the things which I destroyed,
I make myself a transgressor."

If I rebuild the law after receiving Christ, I confess by my actions that His blood was not sufficient. That is why Paul withstood Peter before them all.

Crucified With Christ Means the Old Man Was Destroyed

Galatians 2:19-20 says:

"For I through the law am dead to the law,
that I might live unto God.
I am crucified with Christ:
nevertheless I live;
yet not I,
but Christ liveth in me:
and the life which I now live in the flesh
I live by the faith of the Son of God,
who loved me, and gave himself for me."

I was baptized into His death so I could be quickened together with Him in His life. I live, but not the old "I," because the old man of sin was destroyed.

So what does Paul mean, "Christ liveth in me"? Is that the Holy Spirit? No. Did Jesus Himself step inside me in His human spirit? No.

By the transgression of one man, Adam, sin entered the world and death by sin. You inherited spiritual death from Adam, though you did not have Adam's actual human spirit. You had your own human spirit with the same death that was in Adam's.

Now that you are born again, you have the Spirit of Christ. That does not mean you have Jesus' human spirit. He has His own human spirit, and you have yours. It means the same quickening that brought Him from death to life brought you from death to life. The same new creation God put in Him, He put in you.

That is Christ living in me: the new creation, the new nature, the spirit of Christ in my own human spirit.

Spiritual Death Shows the Terrible Capacity of Sin's Reign

Romans 5 says sin reigned through death. There was no capacity of sin that spiritual death could not carry a person into. That was the nature inherited from the wrong father, which is why we had to be adopted.

When that reality hit me, I did not know what to do with it. If one man could become a Hitler, Lenin, Stalin, or any other figure of mass destruction because sin reigned through spiritual death, then that capacity was in spiritual death itself. It depended on how a person was raised, trained, and used.

That is why law exists. Law is for the lawless. The only thing that governs a spiritually dead man is law, and the penalty must be strong enough to restrain him.

Unrestrained power in the hands of spiritual death always moves toward destruction. History shows the capacity of spiritual death.

The New Nature Has an Equal and Opposite Capacity Toward Righteousness

Romans 5 also reverses the picture. Through the abundance of grace and the gift of righteousness, we reign in life by one, Jesus Christ.

If spiritual death could go all the way backward, the born-again spirit can go all the way forward. I have been born again. There is no limit in the new nature.

God is taking my spirit from glory to glory. Then He sent not merely an angel, but the third Person of the Godhead, the mighty Holy Spirit, to step into my new nature and become my Instructor, Counselor, and Teacher.

With no veil over my face, I look into the mirror of the Word of God and see God in the face of Jesus Christ. The Holy Spirit has the commission to take me from glory to glory, reigning through the abundance of grace and the gift of righteousness all the way to the throne of God.

I have been born again.

The Flesh Can Be Cleansed but the Spirit Goes From Glory to Glory

It is no longer I, the old man who inherited spiritual death from Adam. It is Christ that lives in me. I now possess a human spirit that has been born again, and the life I now live in the flesh I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me and gave Himself for me.

Sin has lost dominion over me. It cannot make me do what I do not want to do or will not do.

Through the abundance of grace, He is changing me from glory to glory. Not my flesh. Flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God. If it cannot inherit the kingdom, it cannot be perfected into the kingdom in its present state.

We will all be changed in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye. Until the trumpet sounds, the best you can do with your flesh is cleanse it from strongholds, soulish patterns, and weaknesses. You can purge it down to basic flesh, but the part going from glory to glory is your spirit.

As your spirit moves from glory to glory, the flesh loses ground. Eventually, to see how you used to be, you have to look far back.

History Helps Us Imagine the Capacity of Life

It is easier to meditate on the capacity of spiritual death because history shows it. We can look at concentration camps, conquest, murder, and people trained from youth into brutality. That shows what sin can do through spiritual death.

But it is harder to meditate on the capacity of a born-again spirit yielded to the Holy Spirit. We have only glimpses, moments when heaven opens and people are healed, delivered, and changed.

If spiritual death had that capacity for evil, what is the capacity of the new nature for righteousness?

Religion will limit you. You need the Holy Ghost as your Teacher. Any teacher who does not teach you how to turn yourself over to the Holy Ghost is failing you, because the Holy Ghost was commissioned to reveal Jesus and guide you into all truth.

Galatians Says the Law Could Not Perfect What Faith Began

Galatians 3:1-9 says:

"O foolish Galatians, who hath bewitched you,
that ye should not obey the truth,
before whose eyes Jesus Christ hath been evidently set forth,
crucified among you?
This only would I learn of you,
Received ye the Spirit by the works of the law,
or by the hearing of faith?
Are ye so foolish?
having begun in the Spirit,
are ye now made perfect by the flesh?"

Paul is asking, "Who is practicing this witchcraft on you?" You began in the new birth. You cannot be perfected by the law.

Abraham believed God, and it was accounted to him for righteousness. Those who are of faith are the children of Abraham. Scripture foresaw that God would justify the heathen through faith and preached the gospel beforehand to Abraham:

"In thee shall all nations be blessed."

Those who are of faith are blessed with faithful Abraham.

The Curse of the Law Was the Inability of Spiritual Death to Keep It

Galatians 3:10-13 says:

"For as many as are of the works of the law are under the curse:
for it is written,
Cursed is every one that continueth not in all things
which are written in the book of the law to do them.
But that no man is justified by the law in the sight of God,
it is evident:
for, The just shall live by faith.
And the law is not of faith:
but, The man that doeth them shall live in them.
Christ hath redeemed us from the curse of the law,
being made a curse for us."

What is the curse of the law? It is that a man born spiritually dead cannot keep it.

Paul says in Romans 7 that the law revealed his sin nature. He did not know covetousness until the law said, "Thou shalt not covet." Something inside rose up, took control, and he could not stop. The good he wanted to do, he could not do.

Something had to happen. The old man had to be destroyed. It is no longer I that live, but Christ lives in me. A new creation freed from sin came into existence in the old man's place.

Christ Was Born Under the Law to Free Those Under Its Curse

Galatians 4:3-5 says:

"Even so we, when we were children,
were in bondage under the elements of the world:
But when the fulness of the time was come,
God sent forth his Son,
made of a woman,
made under the law,
To redeem them that were under the law,
that we might receive the adoption of sons."

Jesus was born under the law and was obligated to fulfill it. He was the first Man born spiritually alive since Adam, so He had a nature that could keep it.

After He kept the law, He stepped into the place of every Jew who could not keep it. He took the curse of their inability onto Himself, died under the penalty of the law in their place, and freed them so they could receive the same adoption Gentiles received.

The Rebellious Son Reveals the Type Behind the Tree

Deuteronomy 21:18-23 speaks of a stubborn and rebellious son who will not obey father or mother. The parents bring him to the elders at the gate, and he is judged. The passage then says that if a man commits a sin worthy of death and is hanged on a tree, his body must not remain there overnight, because he who is hanged is accursed of God.

That is the verse Paul refers to when he says:

"Cursed is every one that hangeth on a tree."

Why is the hanging on a tree connected here with the rebellious son? Because the rebellious son is a type.

Adam fell and received a nature that could no longer keep the commandment of his Father. In that sense he became a rebellious son and came under the death penalty.

The Jew under the law was spiritually dead and could not keep the commandments of the Father. In that manner of speaking, he too stood as the rebellious son.

Jesus stepped into the place of every rebellious, spiritually dead son who could not keep the Father's commandments. He was hung on a tree, became the curse of the law, and died in their place so those under the law could go free and receive adoption as sons.